



Active Listening Guide

Why it Matters

When someone on your team opens up, the way you respond shapes whether they'll ever do it again.

Builds trust and psychological safety

Helps prevent disengagement and silent burnout

Increases employee retention

The 5 Habits of Active Listening



Give Your Full Attention

Your presence is the message. If you're distracted, they'll shut down before they start.

Close your laptop
Silence your phone
Look them in the eyes



Let Them Talk

Let them talk at least 80% of the time (the 80/20 rule). Silence is often when the real stuff shows up.

Don't interrupt
Stay quiet — even through long pauses
Don't rush to reassure or solve



Body Language

Your body language matters more than what you say. Stay physically open and emotionally neutral.

Nod gently and stay relaxed
Avoid defensive postures
Don't roll your eyes



Ask Questions

Ask open-ended questions to clarify what you don't understand — but don't interrogate.

Try: "Can you say a little more about that?" · "What's been the hardest part lately?" · "Do you want to unpack that?"



Repeat It Back

Summarizing what you heard in your own words — not theirs — shows you're listening.

"So what I'm hearing is..." — then pause and let them confirm or correct.

